

THE ART OF THE NYMPH

2.5-Hour Foundations Clinic · Student Handout · Condensed from the Full Program

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2.5 hrs 8:00 AM–10:30 AM	~1.75 hrs ON-WATER TIME	5 SESSIONS	3 TECHNIQUES INTRODUCED
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Contact / Tight-Line · ESP Strike · Indicator Nymphing

Resources: Leader Construction · Fly Casting Terms & Definitions · Fly Fishing Terms & Definitions

QUICK REFERENCE — EIGHT TECHNIQUE PILLARS

TECHNIQUE	EXECUTION & BEST USE
Contact / Tight-Line	Upstream tuck cast, high rod, sighter tracking — most sensitive for close-range complex water.
Indicator Suspension	Yarn, airlock, or dry fly suspends weight — best for distance (25+ ft) and slow flat water.
ESP Strike	Set on any sighter deviation, any hesitation. Set at end of every drift. Never hesitate.
Induced — Ascension	Check rod during drift — current pushes fly upward naturally — mimics emerging nymph.
Leisenring Lift	Cast upstream, track to fish, check rod 4 ft above target — fly rises into fish’s face.

LEADER CONFIGURATIONS

CONFIGURATION	BUILD & BEST USE
Standard Indicator Rig	Tapered leader 9–12 ft, 4X–6X tippet, indicator at 1.5x water depth.
Euro / Mono Rig	20–30 ft of mono — no fly line — sighter + fluorocarbon tippet. Maximum contact and sensitivity.
Sighter Material	Amnesia mono or bi-color indicator mono — your visual strike detection without surface indicator.

ESP STRIKE RULES

RULE	DETAIL
What Triggers the Set	Any sighter deviation: twitch, hesitation, jump, straightening, upstream tick — set immediately.
End-of-Drift Set	Every drift ends with a hook set into the back cast. You will catch fish you never felt take.
Conviction Rule	If you're not sure, you're sure enough. Err toward setting. Never toward hesitation.

WEIGHT CALIBRATION — FINDING THE STRIKE ZONE

#	SIGNAL	ACTION
1	No Ticks at All	Too light. Add weight (split shot or heavier fly) until you feel bottom.
2	Occasional Tick	Target zone. Fly is in the cushion 6–18" off bottom. This is correct.
3	Constant Ticking	Too heavy. Remove weight until occasional tick resumes.

2.5-Hour Foundations Clinic

8:00 – 8:15 am Philosophy, energy economy & gear orientation

PHILOSOPHY + GEAR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the energy economy principle and its application to locating prime lies
- Build a functional Euro/mono rig or indicator rig before going to water

KEY CONCEPTS

Energy economy: food + comfort + protection · Strike zone: 6–18" off bottom in slower current · Tuck cast foundation: high stop, vertical entry, fast sink, natural slack

ACTIVITIES

- Abbreviated leader build: Euro/mono rig or indicator rig depending on group skill level
- Water feature ID: call the energy economy score for 2–3 lies

Checkpoint: Each student's leader is built and functioning before going to the river.

8:15 – 8:25 am · Walk to water

8:25 – 9:25 am Reading water & contact / tight-line nymphing

WATER + CONTACT

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply energy economy to identify prime feeding lies in each water type encountered

- Execute the tuck cast and maintain sighter contact through a complete drift
- Practice the one-seam discipline

KEY CONCEPTS

Tuck cast: high stop, vertical fly entry, fast sink, natural slack for contact · High rod: eliminates line on water — direct sighter-to-fly connection · One seam: both flies stay in the same current seam throughout the drift · Weight calibration: occasional tick = correct — constant tick = too heavy

ACTIVITIES

- Tuck cast drill: repetitions — instructor confirms vertical entry and sink rate
- One-seam discipline: run drifts in a single seam

Checkpoint: Each student achieves a controlled drift in a single seam using the tuck cast.

9:25 – 10:00 am ESP strike — high-probability hook set

ESP STRIKE

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply ESP strike discipline — set on any sighter deviation, end of every drift
- Eliminate the hesitation habit

KEY CONCEPTS

ESP: any sighter twitch, hesitation, or jump = set · End of drift = set · Conviction rule: if unsure, set

ACTIVITIES

- End-of-drift set habit: consecutive drifts all ending in hook sets
- Sighter-deviation drill: partner creates micro-deviations, student sets within 1 second

Checkpoint: Each student demonstrates automatic end-of-drift set habit.

10:00 – 10:20 am Indicator nymphing — depth control & when to choose

INDICATOR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Set indicator depth correctly using the 1.5x rule
- Articulate when indicator wins over tight-line for the water in front of you

KEY CONCEPTS

Indicator at 1.5x water depth — tick bottom, back off 4" · When indicator wins: 25+ ft distance, slow flat water, big water requiring depth

ACTIVITIES

- Depth-setting drill: adjust indicator until nymph ticks bottom, back off to perfect drift

Checkpoint: Each student correctly sets indicator depth and articulates when they'd choose it over tight-line.

10:20 – 10:30 am Final debrief & written feedback

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one priority to build on

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment returned to each student
- One strength and one priority — verbal

Checkpoint: Each student leaves with one written strength and one named priority for the next time on the water.